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ORDER FROM WITHIN

*Dharma Rājyam and the Principles
of Endogenous Governance*



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Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā
Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.

Abstract

Dharma Rājyam remains one of the most frequently invoked yet insufficiently theorised concepts within modern Indian political discourse. References to *Rāma Rājyam*, *dhārmic* order, ethical governance, and civilisational responsibility recur across philosophical, literary, and anti-colonial traditions, yet the underlying concept often remains analytically indeterminate, particularly outside the classical Indian intellectual tradition. Existing treatments frequently approach the idea symbolically, morally, or polemically rather than as a coherent framework of political theory.

This paper reconstructs *Dharma Rājyam* as a structural conception of political order rather than a regime blueprint, theological state, or nostalgic restoration project. It traces the conceptual movement from the narrative archetype of *Rāma Rājyam* toward a generalisable doctrine of disciplined equilibrium grounded in the classical relationship between *dharma*, *artha*, *kāma*, and *mokṣa*. Drawing upon the *puruṣārtha* framework and the dynamic regulatory logic of the *tri-guṇas*, the paper develops a formal analytical model termed the **Dharma Doctrine of Disciplined Equilibrium (DDDE)**.

The paper further examines how this civilisational logic historically manifested across key textual and institutional traditions, including the *Kaccit Sarga* of the *Rāmāyaṇa*, the political realism of the *Mahābhārata*, and the statecraft traditions of the *Arthaśāstra*. It also analyses how civic restraint and social cohesion were cultivated through non-coercive aesthetic pedagogies rooted in the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Finally, the paper situates *Dharma Rājyam* within a modern intellectual lineage extending through Mahatma Gandhi, Sri Aurobindo, and contemporary institutional theory, presenting it as a post-liberal framework that seeks to reconcile institutional realism with ethical restraint, civic self-governance, and long-horizon civilisational stewardship.

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1. Introduction: The Problem of Conceptual Ambiguity

Political traditions rely upon concepts that perform not merely descriptive but orienting functions. Terms such as democracy, republicanism, liberalism, and socialism provide not only institutional vocabularies but also frameworks through which societies understand legitimacy, authority, obligation, and collective purpose. Over time, these concepts acquire extensive theoretical literatures that clarify their foundational assumptions, distinguish their variants, and trace their historical transformations.

Within the Indian intellectual tradition, however, certain politically significant concepts continue to circulate with considerable normative force while remaining comparatively under-theorised in modern analytical terms. Among these is the idea of *Dharma Rājyam*.

References to *Rāma Rājyam* and related notions of *dhārmic* order have periodically appeared across diverse contexts: classical discussions of kingship and *rājadharma*, devotional and literary traditions, reform movements, anti-colonial thought, and contemporary political discourse. Most prominently, Mahatma Gandhi repeatedly invoked *Rāma Rājyam* not as a sectarian state or theological project, but as a condition of justice, restraint, and welfare rooted in moral self-governance.¹ Yet despite the persistence of such references, the underlying concept often remains elusive. The expression functions frequently as an impressionistic aspiration, a metaphor, or civilisational memory, but less often as an object of systematic political inquiry.

Consequently, an important question arises: what precisely is *Dharma Rājyam*? Is it simply a symbolic ideal associated with epic memory? Is it a form of ethical kingship? Does it denote a political arrangement, a moral order, a civilisational aspiration, or some combination thereof? To what extent has it informed historical practice, and to what extent does its contemporary invocation involve reinterpretation or reconstruction?

Such questions become especially significant because contemporary discussions frequently move directly from invocation to application. Appeals to *Rāma Rājyam* or *dhārmic* order

¹ M. K. Gandhi, *Hind Swaraj and Other Writings*, ed. Anthony J. Parel (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), 88–90.

are often connected to present concerns regarding governance, civic conduct, institutional decline, social cohesion, or democratic stability. Yet where conceptual foundations remain unclear, application risks becoming diffused or overly expansive. Concepts that are insufficiently specified can easily become repositories for sentimental longing rather than analytically useful categories.

This paper therefore takes a prior step. Rather than beginning with contemporary democratic crises or institutional engineering, it seeks first to clarify the concept itself. It proceeds from the proposition that *Dharma Rājyam* may be understood not as a rigid regime blueprint, a theological state, or a nostalgic restoration project, but as a broader principle of social and political order grounded in disciplined proportionality, dynamic balance, and calibrated restraint across collective life.

2. From Rāma Rājyam to Dharma Rājyam: The Process of Abstraction and Modern Lineage

Concepts rarely emerge fully formed; they evolve through layers of memory, reinterpretation, institutional adaptation, and changing historical conditions. Political ideas in particular move across multiple registers: narrative, philosophical, ethical, and structural. The genealogy of *Dharma Rājyam* follows precisely such a trajectory, abstracting a structural principle of social order from what first appeared as a symbolic narrative ideal.

Rāma Rājyam occupies a distinctive place within Indian cultural memory. Derived from the narrative universe of the epic, *Rāmāyaṇa*, it came to signify far more than the reign of a particular king or the reconstruction of a historical polity.² Across literary, devotional, and social traditions, it gradually acquired the status of a normative horizon: a condition associated with justice, restraint, social harmony, and responsible, self-limiting sovereignty. Its significance lay less in constitutional detail than in the quality of equilibrium it represented.

Importantly, *Rāma Rājyam* did not function primarily as an immutable administrative

² Vālmīki. *Śrīmad Vālmīki Rāmāyaṇam*. Critical Edition. Edited by G. H. Bhatt et al. Baroda: Oriental Institute, Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda, 1960–1975.

blueprint. Rather, it embodied a civilisational imagination concerning the alignment of authority, responsibility, prosperity, and ethical conduct. It operated through exemplarity rather than procedural specification. The central figure of Śrī Rāma was similarly interpreted not as an absolute monarch possessing unrestricted sovereignty, but as *maryādā puruṣottama*, the exemplary individual whose conduct remained permanently proportionate to obligation, boundary, and role.³ Far from resting on passive exceptionalism, this archetype was maintained through a rigorous, unyielding ethos of internal audit. The operationalisation of this self-limiting sovereignty is immortalised in the *Kaccit Sarga* of the *Rāmāyaṇa*, an entire chapter structured as a continuous, systematic governance review where Śrī Rāma subjects the administrative, fiscal, military, and ethical state of the kingdom to intense interrogation.⁴ This historical archetype establishes that *Rāma Rājyam* was never envisioned as an unexamined myth, but as an active, self-correcting blueprint for continuous institutional audit. The emphasis fell not upon the maximisation of state power, but upon internal self-limitation.

During the twentieth century, this narrative horizon entered a decisive phase of modern reinterpretation through anti-colonial thought, transforming it from an ancient ideal into a rigorous alternative to Western political frameworks. Mahatma Gandhi explicitly rejected readings that understood *Rāma Rājyam* as religious statehood or majoritarian rule. Instead, it represented for him a condition of sovereign justice, extreme decentralisation, ethical conduct, and non-coercive public welfare.⁵ Political freedom from external rule (*svarāj*) remained insufficient without internal moral discipline and self-governance (*ātma-saṃyama*). Civic responsibility and moral formation thus became foundational to political survival.

Parallel to Gandhi's civic formulation, Sri Aurobindo elevated *Dharma Rājyam* to a meta-historical, evolutionary necessity for human collectivities. In his foundational philosophical critique, *The Chariot of Jagannath*, Aurobindo theorised that the ideal human society is not

³ Philip Lutgendorf, *The Life of a Text: Performing the Rāmcaritmānas of Tulsidas* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991), 32–35.

⁴ Vālmīki, *Rāmāyaṇa*, Ayodhyā Kāṇḍa, Sarga 100 (Kaccit Sarga).

⁵ M. K. Gandhi, *Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi*, vol. 75 (New Delhi: Publications Division, Government of India, 1979), 191–94.

a mechanical construction of the intellect or a vehicle for the ‘collective ego,’ but ‘the vehicle of the indwelling Godhead of a human aggregate’.⁶ For Aurobindo, purely external institutional shifts are futile if society remains bound to the competing self-assertions of the ego. True liberation requires a transition wherein the state ceases to be an instrument of coercive coordination and becomes a living vessel for shared civilisational consciousness.

Together, Gandhi and Aurobindo anchor *Dharma Rājyam* in a sophisticated modern intellectual lineage. They sought a post-liberal alternative that bypassed both the atomising individualism of capitalism and the crushing uniformity of state-socialism. This paper extends this historical trajectory through a process of conceptual abstraction. *Rāma Rājyam* expressed *dharma* through narrative memory; the modern lineage applied it to anti-colonial mobilisation; *Dharma Rājyam* articulates the underlying core of that legacy as a structurally generalisable principle of political philosophy. The transition can be mapped as a deliberate analytical progression:

Narrative Archetype → Ethical Horizon → Civic Interpretation → Structural Principle.

In comparative terms, this movement parallels attempts within civic republican and communitarian traditions to ground political stability not merely in institutional procedure, but in cultivated ethical order and public responsibility.

3. The Philosophical Anatomy of Dharma and the Puruṣārthas

The central obstacle to introducing *Dharma Rājyam* to contemporary political science lies in the systemic translation of the term *dharma* itself. In modern Western discourse, *dharma* is frequently rendered as ‘religion,’ ‘law,’ ‘ethics,’ or ‘duty.’ Each translation captures an isolated fragment of its meaning while simultaneously distorting it. Religion suggests creed, dogma, and confessional belief; law suggests codified state command; ethics suggests individual virtue; duty suggests role-specific obligation. Yet *dharma* historically and conceptually encompasses and exceeds these categories.

⁶ Sri Aurobindo, *The Chariot of Jagannath* (Pondicherry: Sri Aurobindo Ashram Trust, repr.), 1.

The Sanskrit root ‘*dhr*’ means ‘to sustain,’ ‘to uphold,’ ‘to bear,’ or ‘to preserve.’⁷ At its broadest level, *dharma* is an ontological and structural principle concerning the conditions under which order is maintained across different scales of existence: cosmic, social, institutional, and individual. It refers not to an imposed command from an external sovereign, but to the internal sustaining alignment that prevents a system from collapsing into chaos. *Dharma* therefore functions not merely as a restraint upon wrongful action, but also as a positive source of orientation that enables forms of conduct aligned with systemic balance and ethical order.

This ontological alignment finds its profoundest material reflection in the etymology of organisation itself. In modern socio-corporate discourse, an organisation is typically conceptualised as a mechanical or bureaucratic assembly; however, the term etymologically derives from the Latin *organum* and the Greek *organon*, denoting a living, internal organ of a biological body.⁸ Just as an organ cannot exist independent of the living organism, *dharma* represents the systemic, organic architecture that translates the raw elements of a collective body into an orderly, self-sustaining whole. This orientation reflects a deeper grounding in *ṛta*, the sustaining cosmic order underlying intelligible existence. If *ṛta* denotes the ontological ground of order, *dharma* may be understood as its normative articulation within human conduct and institutional life.⁹

3.1. The Dynamics of the *Puruṣārthas*

To understand *dharma* as a structural framework for governance, it must be situated within its classical relationship with the other three pillars of human motivation and societal organisation: the *puruṣārthas* (the matrix of human values).

1. **Artha:** The pursuit of material flourishing, economic organisation, commercial wealth, statecraft, and administrative capability.

⁷ Wilhelm Halbfass, *India and Europe: An Essay in Understanding* (Albany: SUNY Press, 1988), 310–15.

⁸ Sudha Seshayyan, “Organisational Dharma of Human Society: Lessons from Human Biology” (distinguished lecture, “Onward March to Rāma Rājya” series, Tattvāloka Auditorium, Chennai, June 24, 2018), YouTube video, accessed May 25, 2026, [YouTube Playlist](#)

⁹ Ibid.

2.Kāma: The pursuit of desire, individual aspiration, aesthetic enjoyment, consumer choice, and self-expression.

3.Mokṣa: The ultimate horizon of liberation, self-mastery, and spiritual or intellectual refinement. In Western classical thought, this ultimate orienting horizon finds its parallel in the Aristotelian conception of *eudaimonia*, the supreme state of human flourishing where life is organised not around transient impulses, but around the realisation of objective, virtuous excellence.¹⁰

Furthermore, within modern developmental psychology, a distant heuristic analogue to *mokṣa* may be found in Abraham Maslow's later concept of self-transcendence.¹¹ Moving beyond self-actualisation, self-transcendence describes a psychological orientation in which the individual voluntarily situates personal ambition within a larger communal, ecological, or civilisational horizon. While *mokṣa* and self-transcendence emerge from fundamentally different philosophical frameworks, the former representing an ontological horizon of liberation and the latter a psychological model of human motivation, the comparison remains suggestive insofar as both point toward a movement beyond possessive self-interest toward wider forms of integration and responsibility. Such orientations help generate the internal dispositions necessary for sustaining structural restraint across collective life.

In this systemic taxonomy, *dharma* does not act as a rejection of *artha* (power/wealth) or *kāma* (desire/freedom). Classical texts like the *Arthaśāstra* and the *Mānava-Dharmaśāstra* explicitly treat material prosperity and human aspiration as indispensable dimensions of political life.¹² Instead, *dharma* functions as the regulative and sustaining horizon within which *artha* and *kāma* must remain embedded. Classical formulations often describe legitimate pursuit as *aviruddha*, namely action that does not stand in conflict with *dharma*.

¹⁰ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, trans. Roger Crisp (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 3–18.

¹¹ Abraham H. Maslow, "The Farther Reaches of Human Nature," *Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* 1, no. 1 (1969): 1–9;

¹² Kauṭilya, *Arthaśāstra*, trans. R. P. Kangle (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1960); Patrick Olivelle, trans., *Manu's Code of Law: A Critical Edition and Translation of the Mānava-Dharmaśāstra* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), 167–75.

Power and desire therefore do not define their own limits. Their legitimacy emerges only when situated within a sustaining framework of proportion and right relation. The framework is ultimately completed by *mokṣa*, which relativises the absolute significance of accumulation, possession, and status. By introducing a horizon beyond immediate acquisition, *mokṣa* stabilises the ethical authority of *dharma* and prevents *artha* and *kāma* from becoming self-justifying ends.

When *artha* (power or market accumulation) or *kāma* (expressive individualism and unchecked desire) break free from the stabilising envelope of *dharma*, they become predatory, generating systemic imbalances that destroy social trust. Conversely, when *dharma* is applied correctly, it ensures that political capability and economic growth reinforce rather than undermine societal durability.

3.2. Differentiated Forms of Dharma

The operational execution of this framework is achieved through a sophisticated, multi-tiered typology of obligations:

- **Sāmānya Dharma:** Universal ethical dispositions necessary to sustain human life across all contexts, independent of one's specific office, identity, or historical position (e.g., truthfulness, non-injury, restraint, reciprocity, and clarity).¹³
- **Viśeṣa Dharma:** Contextual, circumstantial obligations that recognise that what constitutes a sustaining action changes dynamically based on historical conditions, emergencies, and specific relationships.
- **Svadharmā:** Role-specific, situated responsibility tied to an individual's unique disposition (*svabhāva*), capability, and institutional function.¹⁴ Rather than viewing society as a collection of atomised individuals possessing abstract, identical rights, *svadharmic* thought views citizens as differentiated nodes within an interdependent network, where stability is maintained when each node fulfills its situated function.

¹³ P. V. Kane, *History of Dharmasāstra*, vol. 2 (Poona: Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, 1941), 3–15.

¹⁴ *Bhagavad Gītā* 3.35.

- **Rājadharmā:** The specific, highly bounded ethics of political authority. Sovereignty is treated not as a proprietary right or absolute power, but as a strict custodianship exercised under the permanent surveillance of *dharma*.

For modern political scientists, the closest analogue to this structural orchestration is not moral legislation, but constitutionalism. Just as a constitution establishes the meta-rules that enable political life without prescribing every minor choice, *dharma* operates as a regulative horizon orienting conduct, power, and desire toward structural balance. It functions fundamentally not as a theory of absolute sovereignty, but as a comprehensive theory of limitation.

Modern constitutional systems can distribute authority, regulate procedures, and constrain outcomes, but they cannot fully determine the motivations with which power is exercised. This reveals a structural asymmetry at the heart of procedural governance: institutions regulate outcomes, but not motives, which depend upon ethical and cultural conditions beyond formal design.

This limitation exposes the structural vulnerabilities of modern rule-bound architectures. The limitations of purely formal systems are not merely philosophical but structurally demonstrable. As Michael Oakeshott observed, true political durability cannot be secured through mere mechanical ‘rule application’; it demands an underlying, living ‘tradition of practice and judgement’ that guides human actors.¹⁵ When a system attempts to compensate for a decline in internal norms by exponentially expanding external regulations, a pathology termed ‘rule inflation,’ it triggers systemic fragility.

This limitation may be analogically illuminated by Kurt Gödel’s Incompleteness Theorems, which mathematically demonstrate that complex formal systems cannot fully secure their own internal consistency from within their own rules. A polity may struggle to sustain order through procedural expansion alone; it requires an endogenous, self-regulating moral anchor (*dharma*) to discipline the motivations of those who exercise power.

¹⁵ Michael Oakeshott, *Rationalism in Politics and Other Essays* (Indianapolis: Liberty Fund, 1991), 12–15.

4. The Tri-Guṇa Framework of Governance: A Timeless Model of Systemic Balance

To transform *Dharma Rājyam* into a dynamic analytical metric, we must deploy the classical conceptual vocabulary of the *tri-guṇas*, the three fundamental forces or tendencies that govern all psychological, social, and institutional systems: *tamas* (inertia), *rajas* (hyper-activity), and *sattva* (harmony/clarity).¹⁶

By extracting these categories from pure psychology, we can map a timeless sociological taxonomy of governance states. This structural application closely parallels Sri Aurobindo's analysis of the forces driving human aggregates. In '*The Chariot of Jagannath*', Aurobindo utilises the allegory of the chariot to classify the structural maturity of human societies:

- **Tāmasic Governance (The Lower Nature):** Characterised by inertia, rigidity, stagnation, and a blind adherence to dead letters. In this state, institutions exhibit bureaucratic paralysis, over-centralisation, and systematic resistance to adaptation. Aurobindo describes this as a state driven by 'the old and new dull urges of the lower nature,' rendering the collective aggregate unreflective, mechanical, and prone to systemic decay.
- **Rājasic Governance (The Collective Ego):** Driven by hyper-activity, uncontrolled ambition, aggressive competition, and emotional escalation. Institutionally, this manifests as short-term electoral signalling, performative populism, permanent emotional mobilisation, and the fragmentation of the polity into grievance blocs. Aurobindo explicitly identifies this state with 'the collective ego,' warning that 'as long as ego is the master, it is not possible to find the goal... it is not possible to drive the chariot straight.'¹⁷ The society is permanently stimulated but inherently unstable.
- **Sāttvic Governance (Disciplined Equilibrium):** Defined by clarity, structural balance, ethical proportion, and adaptive restraint. Institutionally, it enables long-horizon strategic planning, institutional integrity, civic moderation, and the non-

¹⁶ *The Bhagavad Gītā*, trans. S. Radhakrishnan (New Delhi: HarperCollins, 1993) 14.5–18.

¹⁷ Aurobindo, *The Chariot of Jagannath*, 1.

coercive harmonisation of plural interests. Aurobindo characterises the *sāttvic* vehicle as ‘polished, shining, clean... [going] forward cautiously at an easy pace without any haste along a good road.’¹⁸ This *sāttvic* equilibrium is operationalised within statecraft through the structural mandates of *śreṣṭha dharma* (the ethical obligation of the senior or leader) and *ācaraṇa* (visible, lived conduct).¹⁹ Rather than allowing leadership to remain an abstract moral virtue or a series of focus-grouped communication metrics, the *dhārmic* framework binds institutional elites to the generation of systemic *pramāṇa* (authoritative benchmarks) through their direct actions. *Śreṣṭha dharma* dictates that the structural legitimacy of an institutional hierarchy is maintained only when its leaders model the exact boundaries they seek to enforce, transforming power from a tool of top-down domination into an engine of shared behavioral alignment.

However, expanding on the classical framework, Aurobindo offers a critical warning for political theory grounded in the *Bhagavad Gītā*’s insight that *sattva* binds through attachment to its own light and happiness (*sukha-saṅga*).²⁰ If a society becomes attached to its own *sāttvic* ego, clinging exclusively to a state of pristine institutional peace and intellectual comfort, it risks becoming fiercely protective, risk-averse, and insulated from the vital life-impulses of human development, eventually sliding back into *tāmasic* stagnation. *Dharma Rājyam*, therefore, cannot be conceptualised as a static, conservative freeze on social movement; it must be a dynamic, *sāttvic* balancing mechanism capable of channelling *rājasic* energies without allowing them to fracture into structural chaos.

5. Constituent Principles of the Dharma Rājyam Equation

When reconstructed analytically, *Dharma Rājyam* operates not as an amorphous moral ideal or a rigid regime design, but as a formalised governance diagnostic framework: **The Dharma Doctrine of Disciplined Equilibrium (DDDE)**. The core premise of the DDDE is that stable, long-horizon governance cannot be achieved through procedural institutional

¹⁸ Ibid., 1-2.

¹⁹ M. B. Athreya, “Good Organisational Governance: Lessons from Rāma Rājya,” *Tattvāloka*, May 2020.

²⁰ *Bhagavad Gītā* 14.6.

expansion alone; it requires a simultaneous, dynamic equilibrium across four analytically distinct yet mutually interdependent domains of collective life. Institutional design itself presupposes forms of ethical restraint and motivational discipline that it cannot independently generate.

The DDDE equation is intended as a heuristic governance model rather than a quantitatively predictive formula. Within this architecture, if any single domain undergoes ethical or structural drift, a compensatory distortion is instantly triggered in another, multiplying the state's enforcement expenditures. This systemic vulnerability is clinically mirrored in the biological pathology of multi-organ failure, where a functional collapse in a single, seemingly isolated node initiates an inevitable, cascading breakdown across the entire organism.²¹ Conversely, this structural interdependence contains an adaptive, homeostatic capacity for internal compensation. This is demonstrated neuroplastically by the human cerebral hemispheres: while the left brain typically governs speech, a catastrophic cerebrovascular accident or injury to that hemisphere activates a latent division of labour, stimulating the dormant right brain to dynamically take over and compensate for the lost capability.²²

This principle of mutual support and dynamic compensation provides the foundational logic for the structural architecture of the state. Rather than operating as isolated silos, these quadrants function as a tightly coupled, homeostatic network where a failure or drift in any single quadrant instantly degrades the integrity of the collective whole.

5.1. Public Dharma Rājyam (PDR): The Structural Discipline of Power

The first domain concerns the proportional exercise of sovereign power. Modern states naturally accumulate authority through crisis-driven emergency powers, technological surveillance capabilities, bureaucratic expansion, and jurisdictional overreach. Without an embedded normative brake, this compounding accumulation gradually erodes state legitimacy and public trust. PDR addresses this destabilising dynamic not by weakening or

²¹ Seshayyan, "Organisational Dharma of Human Society."

²² Ibid

hollowing out state capacity, but by disciplining it from within.

The objective of PDR is structural durability, achieved by embedding strict proportionality within executive action, insulating independent ombudsman and review mechanisms from political interference, and aligning fiscal ambition with generational sustainability. A crucial structural asset of PDR is calibrated decentralisation or subsidiarity: authority must reside at the administrative layer closest to demonstrated competence, with higher jurisdictions intervening only where scale, cross-regional coordination, or constitutional integrity explicitly demand it. Excessive centralisation strains systemic legitimacy and stifles civic agency, whereas excessive fragmentation destroys macro-coherence.

The logic of subsidiarity mirrors biological systems, where seemingly small organs often regulate larger systemic processes. Effective governance similarly depends upon preserving the functional autonomy of competent local nodes.²³ Macro-scale administrative centralisation, therefore, misaligns the governance ecosystem by overriding these critical, localised nodes of master authority.

Operationalised within statecraft, this domain is activated by the principles of *śreṣṭha dharma* and *ācaraṇa*.²⁴ The *dhārmic* architecture binds governing elites to the generation of systemic *pramāṇa* (authoritative benchmarks) through their direct actions, ensuring that administrative power remains a custodial responsibility rather than a tool of majority domination or factional capture.

5.2. Corporate Dharma Rājyam (CDR): The Discipline of Fiduciary Capital

The second domain concerns the responsible deployment of capital and market enterprise. While markets remain unparalleled instruments of economic coordination, innovation, and resource allocation, modern corporate governance faces a critical internal failure. As contemporary governance increasingly operates through layered regulatory systems, hybrid public-private arrangements, and dispersed managerial structures, responsibility itself becomes diffused across opaque networks of decision-making. Despite exponential

²³ Ibid.

²⁴ Athreya, “Good Organisational Governance.”

increases in regulatory density, disclosure frameworks, and Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) compliance tracking, institutional collapses persist. This failure occurs because formal legal compliance has proliferated as a downstream check while core corporate incentives and internal behavioral constraints remain fundamentally misaligned. Institutional systems may successfully structure interaction while still failing to orient conduct toward ethical ends.

CDR responds to this structural gap by repositioning ethical discipline as an upstream organising principle embedded directly within the design of enterprise capital. It treats capital as strictly fiduciary rather than predatory, and corporate expansion as a long-horizon custodial stewardship rather than an impulsive extraction of value. Under CDR, capability creation, such as domestic technological depth, manufacturing resilience, and worker skill formation becomes central to the corporate mission rather than peripheral philanthropy.

This upstream calibration seeks to neutralise imbalance before it escalates into systemic breakdown.

Furthermore, CDR recognises that governance breakdowns are invariably behavioral before they manifest structurally; short-termism, opacity, and executive overcompensation accumulate quietly before fracturing into regulatory breaches. Boards are therefore called to anticipate behavioral distortions by enforcing transparent disclosure, proportional compensation limits, and an outward-facing prioritisation of metrics that places external stakeholders, namely, the citizen-beneficiary, the investor-donor, and the broader social-ecological aggregate, at the apex of fiduciary duty.

5.3. Institutional Dharma Rājyam (IDR): The Discipline of Purpose

Standing as a stabilising middle layer between state sovereignty and market capital is the institutional domain. IDR governs the equilibrium of organised civil bodies that structure the character, knowledge, and continuity of a civilisation, including universities, judiciaries, professional associations, trusts, and voluntary public assemblies (*sabhās*). Where PDR disciplines sovereign power and CDR disciplines economic capital, IDR explicitly disciplines

institutional purpose.

The task of this domain is strictly custodial: to preserve the structural integrity and mission clarity of these bodies, ensuring they resist external capture and transmit generational standards without decay. Institutional imbalance and systemic friction emerge through three distinct pathologies: the subsumption of autonomy by political power, the overriding of founding missions by commercial incentives, or the ossification of living traditions into empty, rigid symbolism.

An organisation aligned with IDR maintains clear separation from both state coercion and market extraction by preserving meritocratic leadership, financial self-sufficiency without mission drift, and intellectual autonomy anchored in public responsibility. When these intermediary bodies retain their functional integrity, they deepen public trust and absorb social friction, radically reducing the regulatory and punitive burdens placed upon the state. Like filtering organs within a biological system, intermediary institutions absorb and process social friction before it destabilises the wider polity.

5.4. Prajā Svarājyam (PSR): Civic Self-Governance and Cultural Formation

The final cornerstone of the equation concerns the disciplined self-rule of the citizen (*prajā*). Drawing its intellectual lineage from the Gandhian conception of *Svarāj*, PSR defines freedom not merely as political independence or unconstrained individual choice (*kāma*), but as mastery over internal impulse and responsible participation in community life. Transposed onto contemporary global and digital systems, PSR posits that no constitutional structure can maintain equilibrium if the civic conduct of its citizens remains undisciplined. Laws may compel compliance through surveillance, but durable civilisational order depends upon voluntary restraint.

Crucially, the DDDE recognises that PSR cannot manifest in public life without an interior, psychological foundation: Cultural Formation operates as the interior substratum of civic life. Operating far beneath formal statutes and public policy, cultural formation acts at the level of human discernment, perception, and character cultivation across generations.

Subventions of rights without duties, the displacement of responsibility by permanent grievance, and the hardening of fluid identities into political antagonism are fundamentally symptoms of cultural erosion.

By utilising non-coercive civilisational pedagogies, including aesthetic discipline (*nāṭya*), philosophical inquiry, and reflective study, cultural formation refines the human temperament. It transforms the citizen from a transactional *karmacārī* (an extractive actor focused on rights and material gains) into a duty-conscious *karmayogī* (an actor aligned with a shared public mission).²⁵ Civilisational advancement similarly depends upon citizens moving beyond purely extractive individualism toward shared participation in higher collective purposes.²⁶ Cultural depth refines perception, moderates ambition, and embeds behavioral restraint within the individual long before the law compels it. Civic maturity thus minimises the necessity for external state coercion, establishing internalised character as the ultimate guarantor of democratic governability.

This structural equilibrium may therefore be conceptually expressed through the following domain equation:

$$\mathbf{DR = PDR + CDR + IDR + PSR}$$

where each variable represents a distinct dimension of systemic stabilisation, corresponding to the four sustaining wheels of Sri Aurobindo's civilisational vehicle: Power, Freedom, Knowledge, and Unity.²⁷

Yet institutional design alone cannot generate the civic temperament required for disciplined equilibrium. The deeper question therefore becomes: through what mechanisms are these psychological and cultural dispositions cultivated within society itself?

²⁵ Athreya, "Good Organisational Governance."

²⁶ Seshayyan, "Organisational Dharma of Human Society."

²⁷ Aurobindo, *The Chariot of Jagannath*, 1.

6. Civic Pedagogies: The Aesthetic and Affective Foundations of Order

How is this critical capacity for *Prajā Svarājyam* (PSR) and internal *sāttvic* discipline cultivated within a society? Classical Indian political thought recognised a profound truth that modern institutionalism often overlooks: formal laws and structural rules are insufficient to produce civic virtue. True restraint must be cultivated at the level of human psychology, affect, and emotional modulation.

This insight points directly to the political and civilisational function of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, the classical Indian compendium of dramatic, somatic, and performance theory.²⁸ Within the *dhārmic* tradition, *nāṭya* (performance) was never conceptualised merely as escapist entertainment or elite consumption. Sage Bharata describes *nāṭya* as a comprehensive, non-coercive social art intended to educate, refine, and elevate collective consciousness.

6.1. The Mechanics of Civic Rasa and Sādhāraṇikaraṇa

The structural vehicle for this civic cultivation is the aesthetic process of *Rasa*, the distillation of raw, chaotic human emotions into refined, universalised, and contemplative states of awareness.

In the ordinary public sphere, human interaction is frequently dominated by raw emotional friction (*rajas*): anger, fear, grievance, and status anxiety. Through the performance pedagogy of *sādhāraṇikaraṇa* (aesthetic universalisation), personal emotion is lifted out of its egoistic, atomised context and transformed into a shared, collective experience. The individual learns to witness intense conflict, tragedy, and ambition from a state of reflective distance.

This process cultivates Civic *Rasa*, a shared, experiential public atmosphere through which plurality, disagreement, and political competition remain integrated within a deeper sense of mutual intelligibility and belonging. The disciplined training of the body, speech, gesture, rhythm, and attention required by the *Nāṭyaśāstra* serves as a non-coercive civic pedagogy.

²⁸ Kapila Vatsyayan, *Introduction to Nāṭyaśāstra* (New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1996).

It teaches the citizen expressiveness without chaos, intensity without fragmentation, and engagement without polarisation. Historically, the *sabhā* (the public assembly or performance space) operated as a vital site of shared affective participation where latent social tensions were absorbed, processed, and harmonised back into civilisational continuity.

When a political system relies solely on procedural liberalism, its public square often degenerates into an emotionally exhausting arena of permanent agitation. *Dharma Rājyam* posits that long-term governability requires an aesthetic and affective foundation: a society remains stable only when its cultural and artistic ecosystems continually reproduce the psychological moderation and somatic restraint necessary to make public life liveable.

7. Historical Expressions and the Rejection of Utopia

To ensure that *Dharma Rājyam* operates as a valid category of political theory, it must be defended against the charge of retrospective intellectual fabrication or naive moral perfectionism. The concept is neither an overnight invention nor an unyielding, static bureaucratic monolith. Rather, its historical reality is that of a recurring and adaptive normative lineage that has periodically resurfaced to check raw state power across millennia.

Its historical footprints can be traced through four major tokens of legitimacy:

1. **The Rāmāyaṇa and the Ethos of Internal State Audit:** Within the narrative universe of the *Rāmāyaṇa*, the reign of Śrī Rāma established the foundational civilisational archetype of *maryādā*, an order where sovereignty is permanently bounded by role-specific ethical limitations. Far from resting on passive exceptionalism, this archetype was maintained through a rigorous ethos of internal administrative audit. The operationalisation of this self-limiting sovereignty is structurally codified in the *Kaccit Sarga* of the *Rāmāyaṇa*.²⁹ Written as an interrogation of Bharata by Śrī Rāma, this script serves as a systematic governance

²⁹ Vālmīki, *Rāmāyaṇa*, Ayodhyā Kāṇḍa, Sarga 100.

review, subjecting the state's fiscal health, intelligence frameworks, military readiness, judicial transparency, and care for the vulnerable to an intense ethical audit. This text establishes that the historic archetype of *Rāma Rājyam* was never envisioned as an unexamined myth, but as an active, self-correcting manual for continuous institutional verification. The same textual tradition further extends this audit principle to the ethical qualifications of ministers themselves. Classical descriptions emphasise not merely technical competence (*vidyā*), but humility (*vinaya*), sensory restraint (*niyatendriyatā*), public decorum, and fidelity to justice as prerequisites for political office.³⁰ Governance competence was therefore inseparable from disciplined character formation.

2. **Epic Realism in the Mahābhārata and Arthaśāstra:** In the *Śānti Parva* of the *Mahābhārata*, written in the aftermath of a devastating civil war, governance is framed not as a sentimental utopia, but as a complex, morally hazardous terrain requiring continuous contextual adjudication (*viśeṣa dharma*) rather than the mechanical application of rigid codes.³¹ Similarly, the *Arthaśāstra* demonstrates that even within a highly realistic, granular manual of statecraft, espionage, and taxation, the survival of the state (*artha*) remains fundamentally tied to the preservation of public welfare and the internal self-mastery of the ruler.³² *Artha* (power/wealth) and *dharma* (restraint) were never seen as binary opposites in historical practice, but as mutually dependent vectors; wealth and power were understood to disintegrate rapidly if detached from their sustaining normative envelope.
3. **The Decentralised Network of Sovereignty:** Historically, *Dharma Rājyam* never operated as an all-powerful, centralised bureaucratic state. Instead, it functioned as a profound normative check and balancing network. It bound the sovereign through *Rājadharmā* while simultaneously protecting the internal autonomy of decentralised social organs, namely, guilds, local village councils (*panchayats*), educational networks, and civic assemblies, each operating according to its own *svadhārmic*

³⁰ Ibid.

³¹ Vyāsa, *Mahābhārata*, Book 11–12.

³² Kauṭilya, *Arthaśāstra*.

responsibility. In the contemporary era, this adaptive lineage has moved from anti-colonial political platforms into the domain of modern institutional design and strategic management theory. Contemporary reformulations, notably championed by organisational thinkers such as Dr. M. B. Athreya³³ have actively stripped these principles of their purely mythic character to frame them as immediate blueprints for administrative renewal. This contemporary stream demonstrates that the idioms of *Rāma Rājyam* do not represent a frozen historical relic, but a living, systematic vocabulary of governance that bridges ancient civilisational values with global administrative best practices.

7.1. The Rejection of Utopian Perfectionism

Crucially, this historical lineage avoids the trap of utopian idealism. Critics might argue that a framework relying on internalised restraint is too fragile to survive the gritty realities of political self-interest. However, the *dhārmic* tradition is explicitly built on human limitation and systemic complexity.

Sri Aurobindo directly addresses this vulnerability in *'The Chariot of Jagannath'*, evaluating why previous historical attempts to establish ideal communes have routinely collapsed. Whether inspired by 'the intellectual ideas of the West' or 'intensity of spiritual feeling,' such fragile communes inevitably fail because 'the idea of a restless intellect cannot endure; it is washed away by the irresistible current of old and new life-impulses. An intensity of emotion cannot bring about success in this endeavour; emotion is worn out by its own impetus.'³⁴

For Aurobindo, a true civilisational framework must accommodate, rather than suppress, the raw, competitive impulses of life. *Dharma Rājyam* is explicitly not an intellectual utopia or a moral perfectionist project. It does not assume flawlessly virtuous citizens or saintly rulers. Far from leaning into a sentimental or passive pacifism, the *dhārmic* architecture balances its 'soft' values of compassion (*dayā*) and mercy (*karuṇā*) with a rigorous, realistic

³³ M. B. Athreya, "Rama Rajya Paradigm of Corporate Governance" (keynote address, seminar on *Lessons from Rama Rajya for Good Corporate Governance*, World Trade Center Mumbai and Tattvāloka, Mumbai, February 17, 2020), YouTube video, accessed May 25, 2026, <https://youtu.be/-9Ft2JnwIL0>.

³⁴ Aurobindo, *The Chariot of Jagannath*, 5.

deployment of ‘hard’ state capacities through *daṇḍanīti* (the structural policy of law enforcement, correction, and punitive deterrence for offenders).³⁵ *Dharma Rājyam* explicitly accounts for the realities of human malice, greed, and institutional subversion; it does not expect immaculate virtue. Without ethical anchoring, procedural safeguards themselves risk becoming instruments through which concentrated power negotiates its own limits. *Daṇḍanīti* ensures that when internalised moral restraint fails, the coercive apparatus of the state is deployed with swift, unyielding precision to protect the vulnerable and preserve the systemic equilibrium of the collective whole. Rather, as Aurobindo writes, it is ‘by its very nature a field for the play of work and mutuality.’³⁶ It is a resilient, robust architectural framework designed to withstand, channel, and stabilise the complex life-impulses, friction, and diverse dispositions (*bhāvas*) of ordinary human society through structural equilibrium.

8. Clearing Misreadings: What Dharma Rājyam Is Not

Because the conceptual vocabulary of the Indian tradition remains unfamiliar to mainstream global political science, *Dharma Rājyam* is highly susceptible to systematic misinterpretation. It is critical to explicitly decouple the concept from four predictable misreadings:

- **Dharma Rājyam Is NOT Theocracy:** It does not mean rule by a clerical class, a priestly hierarchy, or the enforcement of a singular confessional dogma. *Dharma* is a non-doctrinal, structural principle of balance and systemic preservation, fully compatible with institutional pluralism and freedom of thought.
- **Dharma Rājyam Is NOT Majoritarianism:** It does not provide a moral justification for the cultural domination of a numerical majority over minority populations. Because *dhārmic* philosophy assumes that plurality is an inherent property of reality, a true *Dharma Rājyam* is structurally committed to protecting diversity,

³⁵ Smt. Vishakha Hari, “A Vision of Rāma Rājya in Our Modern World,” distinguished lecture in the “Onward March to Rāma Rājya” series, Tattvāloka Auditorium, Chennai, April 15, 2018, YouTube video, accessed May 25, 2026, https://youtube.com/playlist?list=PLs8LRdUXZsHkf9HT9qmiUQhYzx5RfZRC0&si=PQS_5zqJwOdc7-c.

³⁶ Aurobindo, *The Chariot of Jagannath*, 5.

constitutional safeguards, and peaceful dissent as vital components of a balanced whole.

- **Dharma Rājyam Is NOT Static Hierarchy:** While historical Indian society unquestionably contained exclusions, structural inequalities, and oppressive stratifications that deserve absolute moral condemnation, the analytical model reconstructed here does not validate inherited social immobility. It focuses entirely on the universal principles of bounded authority, institutional integrity, and civic reciprocity.
- **Dharma Rājyam Is NOT Nostalgic Restorationism:** It does not seek the literal, mechanical replication of a pre-modern political era. The relevance of the concept lies not in historical mimicry, but in its capacity to provide a fresh conceptual vocabulary for evaluating the enduring tensions of power, freedom, and order.

9. Conclusion: Reconstructing Post-Liberal Legitimacy

Modern institutional analysis often treats civic character, psychological moderation, and affective coherence as secondary variables, assuming that formal procedures and constitutional checks alone can secure stability.

The framework of *Dharma Rājyam* offers a corrective to this procedural bias. Constitutional order rests upon a dual foundation: the external structuring of authority and the internal disciplining of motivation. The long-term survival of political order depends upon conditions that precede formal procedure itself. By mapping governance through the *puruṣārthas*, diagnosing systemic imbalance through the *tri-guṇa* framework, and cultivating civic restraint through non-coercive aesthetic pedagogies, *Dharma Rājyam* articulates a comprehensive conception of disciplined freedom. Pluralistic societies inevitably experience periods of friction and polarisation; stability emerges not through suppressing movement, but through restoring equilibrium via mutually regulating institutions and civic restraint.

Dharma Rājyam thus reframes the central question of political philosophy. The primary

challenge for complex societies is no longer exclusively the problem of liberation from authority, but the more difficult task of reconstructing legitimate authority, internalised restraint, and civilisational coherence after liberation has been achieved.

Dharma Rājyam therefore functions less as a substantive programme of state design than as a regulative framework for evaluating whether power, desire, institutions, and civic life remain proportionately ordered.

Having established *Dharma Rājyam* as a doctrine of disciplined structural equilibrium, we may now apply this framework to the *rājasik* crises of fragmentation, performative populism, and accelerating ungovernability destabilising contemporary liberal democracies.
